

**(Working) Alignment as Deterrence:**

**The U.S.-ROK Policy Alignment and North Korea's Provocations (1993-2023)**

## **Abstract**

North Korea is often characterized as an irrational state whose provocations appear unpredictable and strategically incoherent. However, this study argues that Pyongyang's coercive actions are outcomes of a thoroughly calculated strategy designed to exploit structural vulnerabilities within the U.S.-ROK alliance. This study focuses on the 30-year period from 1993—the onset of the first nuclear crisis, to 2023—when North Korea officially redefined inter-Korean relations as “hostile,” after the failure of the Hanoi summit, signaling the complete termination of diplomatic engagement.

By integrating coercive diplomacy theory with the stability-instability paradox, this study elucidates the mechanism of North Korean provocations. North Korea leverages its nuclear capabilities to secure strategic stability with the United States by deterring full-scale war, while simultaneously generating tactical instability through conventional military provocations against South Korea and escalatory rhetorical threats. Through this strategy, Pyongyang seeks economic aid and regime security guarantees. To achieve its most impact, North Korea capitalizes on gaps in U.S.-ROK policy alignment. Within this framework, the primary independent variable determining the frequency and intensity of North Korean provocations is the degree of U.S.-ROK policy alignment.

Using a four-dimensional index (soft-soft, soft-hard, hard-soft, hard-hard policy alignment of U.S.-ROK), this study analyzes specific eight phases between 1993 to 2023. The empirical evidence demonstrates a consistent pattern: when U.S.-ROK policies are aligned—whether soft-soft or hard-hard—North Korea seems relative restraint perceiving a high cost of provocation. Conversely, policy misalignment creates an opportunity structure that lowers the perceived risks, leading to a surge in coercive actions. These findings reframe North Korea provocations not as erratic outbursts but as rational, opportunistic instruments exploiting fragmenting the alliance. The study concludes that maintaining strategic cohesion between Washington and Seoul is as critical as the specific policy orientation itself for preserving stability on the Korean Peninsula.

## I . Introduction

North Korea has long been viewed as an inherently irrational state whose provocations are unpredictable. Since North Korea's provocations have long inconsistently occurred at times regardless of diplomatic openness and during phases of coercive pressure. These patterns defy conventional expectations that softline policies reduce tensions while hardline policies intensify them. Notably, some of the most significant provocations occurred under the most conciliatory administrations, such as the first Yeonpyeong battle in 1999 under the Agreed Framework with Clinton administration and the first nuclear test in Roh Moo-hyun government, which was conciliatory toward the North. This puzzling variability indicates that North Korea's behavior cannot be adequately explained by examining either South Korea's or the United States' policy stance in isolation. Instead, a structural dynamic of U.S.-ROK alignment appears to a deeper analytical blind spot in existing scholarship.

The existing literature tends to follow one of three approaches: U.S-centric analyses, South Korea-centric analyses, or event-specific analyses. These approaches illuminate important dimensions of the issue but fail to capture a critical structural variable, 'the degree of policy alignment between the United States and South Korea.' Although alliance coordination is casually cited in policy discourse, no systematic academic study has examined alignment as an independent variable affecting North Korea's strategic calculations.

North Korea's provocation patterns since 1993 suggest that Pyongyang's behavior differs markedly depending on whether Washington and Seoul present an aligned or misaligned coordination. Specifically, provocations have notably decreased when the U.S.-ROK alliance exhibited well-aligned policies and increased during periods of misalignment. This implies that North Korean provocations are not merely demonstrations of military capability but also calculated responses to the external variable of alliance coordination. Thus, this study introduces policy alignment as an empirically observable variable that affects North Korea's cost-benefit calculations, offering a more coherent and theoretically grounded explanation for North Korea's intention through provocations.

This study hypothesizes that North Korea behaves as a rational strategist employing coercive actions and conceptualizes provocations as deliberate instruments of coercive diplomacy. Provocations are understood as calibrated tools designed to impose costs, shape bargaining environments, and exploit opportunities created by alliance dynamics. When the allies respond incoherently or separately, the costs of provocation will decrease, while the benefits of coercive pressure will increase because one side may concede or moderate in order to maintain diplomatic momentum. Conversely, when the allies are aligned—whether soft-soft or hard-hard—North Korea will face a fortified front, which raises the costs of provocations.

To evaluate this proposition, the study introduces two methodological components: a systematic classification of U.S. and South Korean policy stances using a soft/hard Index, and a research scope limited to the period from 1993 to 2023. During this timeframe, U.S. and South Korean approaches to North Korea will be categorized using a binary framework of 'soft' and 'hard' policy index, enabling a clearer assessment of the degree of policy alignment between the two allies.

Using this classification system, the study examines eight periods of U.S.-ROK policy interaction between 1993 and 2023 with North Korea's provocations. For each period, the degree of policy alignment is identified as the independent variable and correlated with

observable patterns of North Korean provocations, as of the dependent variable. The relationship between these variables will be examined through qualitative analysis of relevant historical and policy records.

With these frameworks, this study yields three central hypotheses. First, higher degrees of U.S.–ROK alignment are associated with lower levels of North Korean provocations. Second, North Korea escalates provocations during periods of policy divergence because such moments heighten the expected effectiveness of coercive diplomacy. *Third, soft–soft alignment is uniquely associated with both low provocation levels and tangible diplomatic progress, whereas hard–hard alignment reduces provocations but does not generate diplomatic breakthroughs.*

By foregrounding alliance cohesion as a central explanatory variable, this study introduces a structural perspective on North Korea’s strategic behavior. It reframes provocations not as erratic outbursts or manifestations of irrational hostility, but as calculated, opportunistic responses to the U.S.–ROK policy alignment.

## II. Theoretical Framework: Coercive Diplomacy and the Stability-Instability Paradox

### 1. Literature Review

It is commonly assumed that hardline policies provoke North Korean resistance, whereas conciliatory policies reduce incentives for provocation and yield greater diplomatic gains. However, this intuitive approach ultimately proves to be detached from reality. For instance, during the Clinton presidency and the Kim Dae-jung (DJ) administration, periods characterized by the most proactive engagement policies, but the First Battle of Yeonpyeong took place in the meantime. Likewise, under the Roh Moo-hyun (Roh) administration, which pursued the Six-Party Talks in an effort to resolve the nuclear issue, North Korea ended up declaring itself a nuclear-armed state. During the Obama administration's comprehensive and peaceful approach, North Korea carried out the sinking of the ROKS Cheonan and the shelling of Yeonpyeong Island.

Under these circumstances, previous studies on North Korea policy have predominantly focused on analyzing the success or failure of a single policy initiative or an isolated event within a specific administration in either the United States or South Korea. While such single-event or single-policy approaches may offer a plausible interpretation of the immediate circumstances, they remain insufficient for explaining North Korea's underlying strategic intentions or discerning provocation patterns in its behavior, leaving a notable analytical gap in the literature.

Moreover, these studies are generally divided into international political and domestic political approaches. For an international political perspective, studies emphasizing international factors tend to interpret North Korea's nuclear development as an inevitable choice for regime survival in the post-Cold War environment. Yet such macro-level analyses fail to account for specific instances such as North Korea's participation in the 1994 Agreed Framework during the Clinton administration, when Pyongyang effectively suspended its nuclear program.

Similarly, analyses focused on domestic political factors often attribute policy failures to a singular policy or personal dispositions of particular leaders. For instance, the W. Bush administration's hardline stance toward North Korea has been explained by President Bush's personal "loathing" of Kim Jong Il or by the influence of neoconservative figures such as Dick Cheney, Donald Rumsfeld, and John Bolton.<sup>1</sup> In South Korea, the limitations of the Sunshine Policy have been ascribed to President Kim Dae-jung's idealism. The Roh Moo-hyun administration's Peace and Prosperity Policy failures have been framed by conservative critics as evidence of governmental incompetence. As a result, these micro-level analyses often fail to capture the structural dynamics between states and the recurring patterns of North Korean provocations, thereby limiting the ability to draw coherent strategic lessons.

Efforts have also been made to identify particular variables through comparative studies of multiple South Korean and U.S. administrations. For example, Jeong Guk Jin (2012) analyzed the occurrence of inter-Korean summits through the lens of South Korean

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<sup>1</sup> Anthony DiFilippo, "Steady State: The North Korean Nuclear Issue from Bush to Obama," *Asian Affairs: An American Review* 41, no. 2 (2014): 65, <https://doi.org/10.1080/00927678.2014.910423>.

presidential leadership.<sup>2</sup> While this study considered both domestic and international variables across administrations from Kim Young-sam (YS) to Lee Myung-bak (MB), it remained narrowly focused on the single variable of summit meetings. Although U.S. factors influencing South Korean presidential decision-making were partially mentioned, the analysis maintained a Korea-centric perspective and neglected the broader implications of U.S.–ROK policy alignment for North Korean strategic behavior.

Cha Jae-hoon, in *Twenty Years of North Korea Nuclear Negotiations: Research Tasks and Issues*, examined 1,605 theses and articles related to the North Korean nuclear issue from 1991 to 2010.<sup>3</sup> He concluded that the South Korean academic community has largely engaged in descriptive rather than structural analyses of the nuclear issue. Cha noted that most studies concentrated on compiling event chronologies or interpreting agreement texts, thereby failing to identify overarching structural patterns. He further argued that such research has been confined to Korean and, to a lesser extent, American perspectives, neglecting a more comprehensive view of the phenomenon. (Cha, 2011) However, his analysis was limited to the nuclear issue alone, excluding other forms of North Korean provocations, and focused exclusively on South Korean scholarship without incorporating U.S. perspectives. Additionally, by concentrating narrowly on the structure of nuclear negotiations, his work overlooked broader North Korea policy dynamics.

## 2. Coercive Diplomacy in Nuclear Weapons

Coercive diplomacy is defined not merely as the application of physical force, but as a political-psychological strategy intended to influence an adversary's cost-benefit calculus through the integrated use of threats and inducements. According to Alexander George, the efficacy of this strategy is contingent upon four critical contextual variables: clarity of demand, specificity of inducement, credibility of the threat, and a palpable sense of urgency.<sup>4</sup>

In addition, when nuclear weapons are introduced into the realm of coercive diplomacy, the strategic landscape shifts from "deterrence by punishment" to a more complex nuclear coercion. In a nuclear environment, the outcome of a crisis is determined not by raw military preponderance, but by the competition in risk-taking. As Thomas Schelling noted, nuclear coercion operates under the "shadow of shared risks," where the actor willing to endure a higher probability of catastrophe gains strategic leverage.<sup>5</sup> Pyongyang utilizes its nuclear capabilities to force a decoupling between Seoul and Washington, questioning whether the U.S. would "sacrifice New York for Seoul." This strategic

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<sup>2</sup> Jeong, Guk-jin [정국진], "Nambuk jeongsang hoedam gaechoe habui yo-in yeon-gu: Lideosip byeonsu reul jungsim euro" [A Study on the Factors of Agreement to Hold Inter-Korean Summits: Focusing on Leadership Variables] (PhD diss., Kyungnam University, 2011), 00.

<sup>3</sup> Cha, Jaehoon. "A Study of the Correlation between N. K. Awareness and Nuclear Policy of the Korean and US Governments." *Journal of political science and communication* 17, no. 2 (2014): 1. <https://doi.org/10.15617/psc.2014.12.17.2.1>.

<sup>4</sup> Alexander L. George and William E. Simons, eds., *The Limits of Coercive Diplomacy*, 2nd ed. (Boulder: Westview Press, 1994), 7-11.

<sup>5</sup> Todd S. Sechser and Matthew Fuhrmann, *Nuclear Weapons and Coercive Diplomacy* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2017), 35-42.

manipulation of risk is most effective when the alliance fails to present a unified policy front, thereby increasing the perceived rewards for North Korean brinkmanship.

From this perspective, North Korea's provocations can be interpreted as a calibrated strategic choice to test the "credibility of threat" and "sense of urgency" regarding Pyongyang's nuclear program. While acknowledging these strategic variants, this study focuses on the overarching mechanism of coercive diplomacy itself to elucidate North Korea's strategic intentions across a comprehensive thirty-year period, rather than engaging in a granular classification of individual incidents.

### 3. The Stability-Instability Paradox: Tactical Fragility under Strategic Balance

The "Stability-Instability Paradox," primarily articulated by Robert Jervis, posits a paradoxical relationship between strategic deterrence and tactical conflict. Jervis argues that while the condition of Mutual Assured Destruction (MAD) fosters strategic stability by precluding the possibility of total war, it simultaneously incentivizes tactical instability by lowering the threshold for conventional or localized provocations. Under the umbrella of nuclear parity, an aggressor may believe that the defender will refrain from a robust conventional response out of fear that it might escalate to a nuclear exchange.<sup>6</sup>

This strategic irony was early identified by B.H. Liddell Hart, who cogently argued that as the great deterrent (nuclear weapons) makes total war an act of mutual suicide, it inadvertently fosters a sanctuary for limited war and sub-total aggression.<sup>7</sup> Liddell Hart observed that the very paralyzing effect of nuclear weapons on major military operations invites the adversary to exploit the gray areas of conflict.

The essence of the paradox, as refined by Glenn Snyder, lies in the counterintuitive certainty it provides to the aggressor. Snyder argues that as the nuclear deterrent becomes more stable at the strategic level, it paradoxically grants the challenger a "shield of impunity."<sup>8</sup> Since both sides are paralyzed by the fear of an apocalyptic escalation, the aggressor operates under the conviction that the defender will hesitate to deliver a decisive conventional retaliation.

For a provocateur like North Korea, the "strategic umbrella" provided by its nuclear arsenal serves as a prerequisite for its "tactical sword," enabling localized provocations that are carefully calibrated to remain below the threshold of a systemic nuclear response. Consequently, this strategic stability creates a sanitized space for low-level aggression, emboldening the regime to exploit the U.S.-ROK alliance's tactical vulnerabilities without the fear of systemic collapse.

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<sup>6</sup> Robert Jervis, *The Meaning of the Nuclear Revolution: Statecraft and the Prospect of Armageddon* (Ithaca: Cornell University Press, 1989), 19-22, <https://www.cornellpress.cornell.edu/book/9780801495656/the-meaning-of-the-nuclear-revolution/>.

<sup>7</sup> B. H. Liddell Hart, *Deterrent or Defense: A Fresh Look at the West's Military Position* (London: Stevens & Sons, 1960), 23-25; Glenn H. Snyder, "The Balance of Power and the Balance of Terror," in *The Balance of Power*, ed. Paul Seabury (San Francisco: Chandler, 1965), 184-201.

<sup>8</sup> Glenn H. Snyder, "The Balance of Power and the Balance of Terror," in *The Balance of Power*, ed. Paul Seabury (San Francisco: Chandler, 1965), 184-201.

### III. Research Design: Measuring Alliance Alignment and Provocation Patterns

#### 1. Temporal Scope and Case Selection: 1993-2023

The temporal scope of this study spans three decades, from 1993 to 2023. The year 1993 serves as the critical time, marking the onset of the first North Korean nuclear crisis following Pyongyang's announced intent to withdraw from the NPT. This event initiated a sustained nuclear trajectory that continues to define the security architecture of the Korean Peninsula. The study concludes in 2023, a year characterized by a profound shift in North Korea's strategic orientation, following the diplomatic impasse of the 2019 Hanoi Summit; Pyongyang has increasingly pivoted toward a decoupling strategy from the ROK-U.S. alliance while fortifying strategic ties with Russia and China.

#### 2. Operationalizing the Independent Variable: Soft/Hard Index

To minimize subjective bias and ensure analytical consistency, this study operationalizes ROK-U.S. policy orientations through a composite "Soft/Hard Index." This index evaluates each administration's stance across four distinct dimensions:

- **Diplomatic Posture:** Distinguishes between "Soft" approaches (prioritizing unconditional dialogue and engagement) and "Hard" approaches (imposing strict preconditions or maintaining skepticism toward negotiations).
- **Sanctions Orientation:** Differentiates between policy flexibility including sanctions relief or economic incentives, and the rigorous enforcement or expansion of punitive sanctions.
- **Military Posture:** Ranges from "Soft" stances, such as the reduction or suspension of military exercises and de-escalatory gestures, to "Hard" stances characterized by large-scale joint drills and the frequent deployment of U.S. strategic assets.
- **Rhetorical Signaling:** Captures the tone of official messaging, contrasting themes of reconciliation and peacebuilding with adversarial framing centered on deterrence and military readiness.

In instances where indicators across the four dimensions do not converge on a single orientation, the final classification of 'Soft' or 'Hard' is determined through a comprehensive qualitative assessment. 'Diplomatic Posture' is assigned the highest analytical weight, as it most directly reflects the administration's primary strategic intent.

Rather than relying on subjective impressions, the index evaluates each administration across four dimensions: diplomatic posture, sanctions orientation, military posture, and rhetorical signaling. Diplomatic posture distinguishes between unconditional dialogue and engagement-first approaches versus negotiation preconditions and skepticism toward talks. Sanctions orientation differentiates between flexibility or sanctions relief and the expansion or strict enforcement of sanctions. Military posture ranges from reductions in exercises or de-escalatory gestures to large-scale joint drills and the deployment of strategic assets. Rhetorical signaling captures whether official messaging emphasizes reconciliation and peace or deterrence and adversarial framing. These indicators generate composite scores that enable transparent cross-period comparison. The goal is not to capture every nuance of foreign policy, but to establish a consistent analytical baseline for identifying periods of alignment—defined as moments when both governments exhibit

clearly soft or clearly hard orientations—and misalignment, when one leans soft and the other hard.

Given that policy orientation can shift even within a single administration, classification is conducted at the level of distinct policy periods rather than entire administrations. A notable example is the first term of the Trump administration, which initially adopted an extremely hardline posture epitomized by the “fire and fury” rhetoric but later demonstrated elements of diplomatic engagement. This temporal variation is accounted for by classifying policies according to their characteristics at specific points in time.

To address these gaps, this study shifts the analytical focus from the individual states’ North Korea policy to the synergy between U.S.–ROK policy. Given that changes in administrations and shifting domestic and international conditions make perfect policy alignment between the two allies unlikely, this study identifies that moments of policy discord or divergence between Washington and Seoul have coincided with spikes in high-intensity North Korean provocations. By reframing patterns of North Korean behavior through the variable of “alignment gaps” in the U.S.–ROK policy, this research aims to provide a more coherent explanation of provocation trends and to clarify Pyongyang’s underlying strategic objectives.

### 3. Categorizing Provocations: Beyond Armed Action to Rhetorical Signaling

In this study, 'North Korean provocations' include both high-intensity provocations such as nuclear tests, military clashes with South Korea, and long-range missile (ICBM) launches, as well as low-intensity provocations like short-range ballistic missile launches and aggressive statements. Given that this study analyzes North Korea's provocative patterns through a chronological approach from 1993, the intensity and frequency of provocations may vary depending on the evolutionary stage of North Korea's nuclear and missile programs. Therefore, this analysis emphasizes the contextual sequence of events surrounding each provocation rather than raw counts or intensity metrics alone.

#### **IV. Empirical analysis: Policy Alignment as a Determinant of Stability**

##### **1. Periods of Convergence: Suppression of Provocations under Aligned Fronts**

###### **1.1 Clinton – YS & DJ (1993-2001): Soft-Soft**

In the immediate aftermath of the Cold War, both the United States and South Korea were highly vigilant about the possibility of another conflict, favoring proactive diplomacy over coercive measures. However, the First North Korean Nuclear Crisis, triggered by North Korea's 1993 announcement of its withdrawal from the Nuclear Non-Proliferation Treaty (NPT), escalated military tensions on the peninsula to their highest level. The Clinton administration even considered a preemptive strike against North Korea. When President Clinton called President Kim Young-sam (YS) to share U.S. military plans, President Kim firmly opposed any military action to prevent war on the peninsula, averting immediate conflict. This tense standoff eventually found a diplomatic resolution with the October 1994 "Agreed Framework (Geneva Agreement)" between the U.S. and North Korea.

The agreement stipulated that in exchange for freezing North Korea's nuclear development program, North Korea would receive political and economic compensation from the United States. Under the agreement, the U.S. promised to provide two 1,000 MWe Light Water Reactors (LWRs), which would make plutonium production for nuclear weapons difficult, in return for dismantling North Korea's graphite-moderated reactors. Additionally, to compensate for North Korea's energy loss until the completion of the LWRs, the United States agreed to supply 500,000 tons of heavy fuel oil annually. Initially wary of South Korea being excluded from the North Korea-U.S. agreement, President Kim eventually accepted the Geneva Agreement and decided to cover 70% of the cost for constructing the LWRs. Based on this economic support, the Korea Peninsula Energy Development Organization (KEDO), an international consortium led by South Korea, the U.S., and Japan, was established in 1995. KEDO served as a supervisory body for the implementation of the agreement and as one of the few channels for communication and exchange between North Korea and the international community. As part of confidence-building measures, the large-scale U.S.-ROK joint military exercises "Team Spirit" were suspended at this point, and in return, North Korea froze nuclear facilities, including the 5 MWe reactor and reprocessing facilities (radio-chemistry laboratory), and accepted inspections by the International Atomic Energy Agency (IAEA). North Korea suspended the construction of 50 MWe and 200 MWe reactors under development, refrained from significant strategic provocations like as missile launches for an extended duration, and outwardly exhibited a conciliatory stance about the execution of the agreement.

This stability was further solidified during the Clinton administration and South Korea's Kim Dae-jung (DJ) administration, from 1998 to 2003. Through the so-called "Sunshine Policy," the Kim Dae-jung administration actively promoted reconciliation and cooperative exchanges with North Korea. This approach was rooted in President Kim Dae-jung's long-standing political philosophy advocating peaceful coexistence between the two Koreas since the 1970s and is considered South Korea's most proactive policy of engagement toward the North.<sup>9</sup> The Clinton administration formally supported Kim Dae-jung's North Korea policy, and at the time, Secretary of State Madeleine Albright

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<sup>9</sup> Jeong, "Nambuk jeongsang hoedam gaechoe habui yo-in yeon-gu," 12-13.

expressed full backing for the Sunshine Policy.<sup>10</sup> Under this "soft-soft" cooperative framework between the U.S. and South Korea, tangible achievements such as the freeze of North Korea's nuclear development and deterrence of provocations seemed to have been realized.

Nonetheless, this period of stability began to exhibit fissures as a result of changes in U.S. actions. Unlike the U.S. government tasked with executing the Geneva Agreement, the U.S. Congress, predominantly controlled by Republicans at that time, shown considerable skepticism regarding assistance to North Korea. Congress deliberately delayed budget approval for heavy fuel oil supplies and KEDO-related projects, citing North Korea's missile development and human rights issues. In the meantime, North Korea faced extreme economic hardship known as the "Arduous March," especially after the death of Kim Il-sung in 1994. The delayed economic compensation stipulated in the agreement posed a significant threat to regime stability in North Korea. Consequently, Pyongyang engaged in calculated provocations to pressure the United States into fulfilling its commitments and to reinvigorate the momentum of the agreement. The launch of the Taepodong-1 missile in August 1998 and the First Battle of Yeonpyeong in June 1999 can be understood in this context. Particularly, the Yeonpyeong battle, which directly targeted South Korea during a period of proactive engagement policy, exemplified coercive diplomacy aimed at striking the weakest link in the U.S.-South Korea alliance to maximize pressure on the United States.<sup>11</sup>

In other words, the Clinton-DJ period, while seemingly marked by smooth bilateral policy coordination, was in reality undermined by domestic political constraints on U.S. agreement implementation, creating cracks in U.S.-South Korea cooperation. North Korea exploited this gap to carry out military provocations to advance its strategic objectives.

## 1.2. W. Bush – MB (2008-2009): Hard-Hard

The approximately one-year period covering the final year of the Bush administration and the early phase of the Lee Myung-bak government was the only time when both South Korea and the U.S. pursued a hardline approach toward North Korea. Although the Bush administration showed somewhat conciliatory gestures in its later stage compared to its earlier years, it still maintained a hardline stance on North Korea. Meanwhile, South Korea, with the conservative party coming to power for the first time in ten years, adopted a firm stance from the outset.

North Korea sharply criticized Lee Myung-bak's hardline approach and, in March 2008, withdrew all South Korean Ministry of Unification staff stationed at the Kaesong inter-Korean Economic Cooperation Office. However, this effectively only suspended the ongoing consultation channels between the two Koreas, and no subsequent provocations

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<sup>10</sup> Kim, Dae-jung [김대중]. *Kim Dae-jung jaseojeon 2* [The Autobiography of Kim Dae-jung, vol. 2] (Paju: Samin, 2010), 76.

<sup>11</sup> Even immediately after the First Battle of Yeonpyeong, President Kim Dae-jung maintained a policy of peaceful engagement with North Korea, ultimately achieving the first-ever inter-Korean summit on June 13, 2000, and issuing the June 15 North-South Joint Declaration. While this example illustrates the firm resolve of the South Korean government compared to the then-unstable U.S. policy toward North Korea, it has been omitted from the main text to maintain the narrative flow leading into the Bush administration following the U.S. presidential transition.

or military actions followed. During this period, North Korea conducted three missile launches, but all were limited to short-range missiles. Contrary to expectations, after the provisional U.S.–DPRK agreement on April 28, 2008, North Korea implemented the agreed terms and refrained from any hostile actions.<sup>12</sup>

Although this period lasted just over a year and may offer limited data for drawing firm conclusions about North Korea's behavior and intentions, a comparison with patterns of provocations before and after suggests that North Korea remained relatively quiet during this time. With South Korea's policy line shifting after a decade, North Korea may have initially adopted a "wait-and-see" posture. However, considering North Korea's history of provocations under coercive diplomacy, it is unlikely that its restraint was purely passive. Given that North Korea's actions have typically been strategically calculated, it can be inferred that when both sides maintain hardline policies, provocations would only further escalate tensions without allowing North Korea to fully control the situation as it might have desired.

### 1.3. Trump 1<sup>st</sup> – Moon (2018-2019): Soft-Soft

In particular, taking advantage of the 2018 PyeongChang Winter Olympics held in South Korea, efforts to improve inter-Korean relations were actively pursued, leading to the resumption of inter-Korean dialogue. On April 27, 2018, the 3rd Inter-Korean Summit was held at Panmunjom, where the 'Panmunjom Declaration for Peace, Prosperity, and Unification of the Korean Peninsula' was announced. Subsequently, the 4th summit took place in Pyongyang on May 26, and the 5th summit on September 18, resulting in the 'Pyongyang Joint Declaration of September 19.'<sup>13</sup> In conjunction with these declarations, the 'September 19 Military Agreement' was adopted, detailing specific measures to substantially reduce military tensions and prevent accidental clashes on the peninsula.<sup>14</sup>

Based on the denuclearization measures outlined in these declarations, and under President Moon Jae-in's active mediation in his belief that the U.S.-DPRK dialogue as central to denuclearization, the first-ever U.S.-DPRK Summit was held in Singapore on June 12, 2018. At this summit, President Trump and Chairman Kim Jong-un signed a

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<sup>12</sup> On April 28, 2008, a U.S.–North Korea working-level meeting was held in Singapore, resulting in a provisional agreement on the North Korean nuclear issue. North Korea indirectly acknowledged the existence of its highly enriched uranium (HEU) program and its nuclear cooperation with Syria through a separate document (confidential minute) rather than the prior formal declaration, and the U.S. recognized this and sought a compromise. North Korea provided documents related to the Yongbyon reactor to the U.S., and the U.S. agreed to remove North Korea from the list of state sponsors of terrorism and to suspend the application of the Trading with the Enemy Act.

<sup>13</sup> Through the September 19 Pyongyang Joint Declaration, North Korea pledged to permanently dismantle the Dongchang-ri engine test site and missile launch pads under the observation of relevant international experts. Furthermore, North Korea officially indicated for the first time its willingness to take additional measures, such as the permanent dismantlement of the Yongbyon nuclear facilities, contingent upon reciprocal actions by the United States. This commitment would later become a central agenda item in subsequent North Korea–U.S. negotiations.

<sup>14</sup> The "Military Agreement for the Implementation of the Panmunjom Declaration" (the September 19 Military Agreement), adopted as a supplementary accord to the September 19 Pyongyang Joint Declaration, established buffer zones on land, sea, and in the air, and specified concrete measures to prevent accidental clashes. These included the phased withdrawal of observation posts (GPs) within the DMZ and the demilitarization of the Joint Security Area (JSA) at Panmunjom.

joint statement comprising four points, explicitly committing to “work toward the complete denuclearization of the Korean Peninsula.” Although later disputes over the interpretation of specific terms contributed to the breakdown of negotiations, the summit stands as a representative success of unprecedented diplomatic achievement enabled by close U.S.–ROK North Korea policy alignment.

During this period, North Korea completely suspended all forms of provocations, including nuclear tests and missile launches, clearly demonstrating deliberate restraint in a peaceful negotiation phase. Even reviewing infographics released by CSIS, considering North Korea’s previous and subsequent patterns of provocations, it is evident that halting all provocations during this period was highly unusual. In other words, close U.S.-ROK coordination confirms that North Korea intentionally refrains from provocations when a peaceful negotiation path is firmly maintained.



Figure 2 CSIS, <https://missilethreat.csis.org/country/dprk/>

## 2. Periods of Divergence: Exploiting Alliance Fissures through Coercive Leverage

### 2.1. W. Bush – DJ & Roh (2001-2008): Hard-Soft

This period represents a typical intersection between the ‘hard’ stance of the U.S. Republican Party and the ‘soft’ approach of South Korea’s democratic administration, during which North Korea was able to escalate provocations while accumulating justification for its nuclear development by exploiting divergence in U.S.-ROK policy coordination.

The inauguration of the George W. Bush administration in 2001 marked a turning point in U.S. policy toward North Korea, shifting completely from engagement to a hardline approach. President Bush personally expressed “loathing” toward Kim Jong-il and, influenced by neoconservatives, grouped North Korea with Iran and Iraq as part of the so-called “Axis of Evil,” thereby casting a negative view on the Clinton administration’s Agreed Framework in Geneva. As a result, U.S. policy with North Korea transitioned quickly from a focus on diplomacy and negotiation to an emphasis on pressure and sanctions, which was recognized as hardline approach.

Despite this U.S. policy shift, President Roh Moo-hyun (Roh) attempted to ease tensions on the Korean Peninsula through independent inter-Korean economic cooperation and exchanges, following the sunshine policy of the Kim Dae-jung administration. However, the misalignment between the U.S.’s hardline approach and South Korea’s engagement policy

caused serious discord in the U.S.-ROK strategy toward North Korea. Taking advantage of this 'hard-soft' rift, North Korea launched the Second Battle of Yeonpyeong in 2002. While South Korea was managing this incident, U.S. Deputy Secretary of State James Kelly visited North Korea in October of the same year and raised suspicions about North Korea's highly enriched uranium (HEU) program. In response, the United States halted its heavy fuel oil supply to North Korea in December. Consequently, North Korea officially withdrew from the NPT in January 2003, and thereafter reactivated its reactor, triggering the second North Korean nuclear crisis.

During this time, President Roh continued to send peace messages to North Korea, maintaining efforts to resolve the nuclear issue. For instance, President Roh proposed U.S.-North Korea bilateral talks through a ROK-U.S. Foreign Ministers' meeting shortly after taking office in March 2003. President Roh also dispatched unofficial special envoys to facilitate inter-Korea dialogue.<sup>15</sup> With South Korea's efforts and China's mediation, Six-Party Talks ended up being arranged, taking place six times from 2003 to 2008.<sup>16</sup> However, differences between North Korea and the United States over denuclearization persisted, leaving the Six-Party Talks deadlocked until the third round of negotiations.<sup>17</sup> While North Korea demanded simultaneous actions, U.S. hardliners insisted on measures including complete, verifiable, and irreversible denuclearization (CVID), the Proliferation Security Initiative (PSI), and the International Atomic Energy Agency (IAEA) inspections, and no convergence of views was reached.

When the talks reached an impasse, North Korea proclaimed itself a nuclear state in February 2005, leading the United States to recommence discussions. After two stages of marathon negotiations, the September 19 Joint Statement was adopted, in which North Korea pledged denuclearization and NPT return, and the U.S. agreed to discuss light water reactor provision.

However, the Bush administration froze North Korea's Banco Delta Asia (BDA) accounts the day after the September 19 Joint Statement, halting the talks once again. In response, North Korea launched the Taepodong missile in July 2006 and carried out its first nuclear test in October.

Around this time, the U.S. Congress shifted the majority from Republicans to Democrats with the midterm elections, showed signs of softening the hardline stance reflecting on the failures

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<sup>15</sup> During this period, former Chungnam Governor Ahn Hee-jung met with Ri Ho-nam of North Korea in China on October 20, 2006, shortly after North Korea's first nuclear test. At the time, all official inter-Korean communication channels were blocked, and this secret contact was conducted without the prior notification procedures required under the South Korea's Inter-Korean Exchange and Cooperation Act. Although this later drew strong criticism from opposition parties, President Roh Moo-hyun acknowledged in the Cabinet meeting of April 2007 that the action had been carried out under his instruction and explained that it was an unavoidable measure taken for national security in a crisis situation.

<sup>16</sup> [The Six Party Talks](#), multilateral dialogues that consist of the United States, South Korea, North Korea, China, Japan, and Russia.

<sup>17</sup> The third round of the Six-Party Talks took place from June 23 to 26, 2004. The United States proposed specific measures for "denuclearization first, followed by improvement of relations," but North Korea rejected this, regarding it as a de facto demand for prior denuclearization, which caused the talks to reach an impasse.

of Bush's North Korea policy. As a result, the Six-Party Talks resumed, culminating in the February 13 Agreement, which incorporated implementation measures for the September 19 Joint Statement.<sup>18</sup> Encouraged by this momentum, an inter-Korean summit was also held that year.<sup>19</sup>

During this period, while the United States showed some fluctuation in its North Korea policy, it fundamentally maintained a hardline stance, whereas South Korea sought to pursue a consistent peace-oriented, softline approach. While the two countries followed different paths, North Korea declared itself a nuclear state and conducted nuclear tests. While the previous administrations had halted North Korea's nuclear program through a cohesive policy alignment, discord between the United States and South Korea during this period afforded North Korea both justification and opportunity.

This does not categorically deny that North Korea initially lacked intentions to implement the agreements or actively pursued nuclear development. At a minimum, Pyongyang halted provocations during the course of the agreements. However, whenever the United States or South Korea diverged in opinion or delayed progress, North Korea consistently resorted to provocations to advance its agenda.

## 2.2. Obama – MB & Park (2009-2017): Soft-Hard

This period, beginning with President Obama's inauguration in the U.S. and spanning the conservative administrations of Lee Myung-bak (MB) and Park Geun-hye (Park) in South Korea, was marked by a divergence in U.S.–South Korea North Korea policies along a Soft–Hard configuration. It is considered the period of North Korea's most severe provocations, including its from 2nd to 5th nuclear tests, long-range missile launches, and maritime provocations. In June 2009, the North Korean Foreign Ministry spokesperson publicly declared a full confrontation with the U.S., and in November 2009, North Korea engaged in the Battle of Daecheong, followed by the sinking of the Cheonan in March 2010 and the shelling of Yeonpyeong Island in November, bringing North–South and U.S.–DPRK relations to a nadir.

In the United States, President Obama inaugurated in January 2009 and emphasized “direct diplomacy,” implementing a North Korea policy based on “A New Comprehensive Approach.” The Obama administration generally favored diplomatic engagement and actively supported inter-Korean summits, maintaining a peace-oriented approach. By contrast, the ruling conservative party largely pursued a hardline stance, exemplified by the “Denuclearization First 3,000” policy, emphasizing principled engagement with North Korea.

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<sup>18</sup> The fifth round of the Six-Party Talks faced difficulties due to U.S. financial sanctions against North Korea (the BDA issue) and was conducted from 2005 to 2007. The first phase, held from November 9 to 11, 2005, ended without any significant results due to North Korea's strong opposition to the U.S. financial sanctions. The second phase, resumed 13 months later after the U.S. midterm elections, also failed to reach an agreement, as North Korea maintained a firm stance that no progress on nuclear discussions could be made until the BDA issue was resolved, leading to a suspension of the talks. The third phase, held from February 8 to 13, 2007, was dramatically resumed after the U.S. signaled its willingness to address the BDA issue, resulting in the adoption of the February 13 Agreement, which included initial steps for the implementation of the September 19 Joint Statement.

<sup>19</sup> President Roh Moo-hyun and Chairman Kim Jong-il held an inter-Korean summit in Pyongyang from October 3 to 4, 2007, and announced the “Declaration on the Advancement of Inter-Korean Relations and Peace and Prosperity” (the October 4 Declaration). [+ Context](#)

Domestic criticism of previous liberal administrations' conciliatory approach, which was seen as ineffective in curbing North Korea's nuclear development, further strengthened support for this hardline strategy.<sup>20</sup>

During this period, North Korean leader Kim Jong-il's health rapidly deteriorated, accelerating internal succession preparations. In need of economic support to do it, North Korea, despite South Korea's hardline stance, proactively proposed an inter-Korean summit for the first time.<sup>21</sup> South Korea attempted to pursue the summit negotiations in secret, but the U.S. Department of Defense publicly announced the discussions first on purpose.<sup>22</sup> Jung Guk-jin (2012) interprets this as the United States using the announcement to exert indirect pressure on inter-Korean talks, given the tense situation at the time. Additionally, U.S. Secretary of State James Steinberg issued statements supporting the inter-Korean summit, showing strong U.S. support for South Korea's diplomatic approach. However, the summit ultimately failed to materialize. According to Lee Myung-bak's memoirs, South Korea did not compromise its principled "denuclearization first" approach in response to North Korea's economic requests. In retaliation, North Korea carried out the Cheonan attack in March 2010. The Lee administration responded strongly, implementing the May 24 Measures to fully suspend inter-Korean trade, but North Korea persisted, executing the Yeonpyeong Island shelling in November. By December 2011, North Korea declared through the National Defense Commission that it would no longer engage with South Korea.<sup>23</sup>

Separately, the United States began discussions to resume the Six-Party Talks through high-level meetings with North Korea in 2011, including talks on food assistance.<sup>24</sup> The Obama administration kept channels open for dialogue and continued to support the Six-Party framework to address the North Korean nuclear issue. These efforts culminated in the February 29, 2012 agreement between the United States and North Korea, in which North Korea agreed to a moratorium of its nuclear program, including uranium enrichment activities, allowed IAEA inspections, and suspended long-range missile launches, while the United States agreed to resume 240,000 tons of food aid in return.

Immediately following the agreement, however, North Korea launched what was believed to be a long-range missile, the Kwangmyŏngsŏng-3 satellite, believed to violate the agreement.

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<sup>20</sup> A March 2008 public opinion poll showed that 73.4% of respondents believed that the previous government's engagement-oriented policy required revision or supplementation.

<sup>21</sup> Following the death of former President Kim Dae-jung, a high-level North Korean delegation—including Kim Ki-nam, Secretary of the Workers' Party, and Kim Yang-gon, Head of the United Front Department—visited Seoul. They met with President Lee Myung-bak and conveyed messages from Chairman Kim Jong-il regarding a potential inter-Korean summit. This visit led to secret working-level contacts later in 2009 in Singapore to prepare for a confidential summit between the two leaders.

<sup>22</sup> "Cheon-gi nuseol? Bulhyeop hwa-eum?" [Leak of a State Secret? Discord?]. *The Dong-A Ilbo* [동아일보], October 19, 2009.

<sup>23</sup> Yang, Man-hee [양만희]. 2012. "Buk, 'jeongdanghan haengdong'...namcheuk jomun jehan geodeup binan" [North Korea calls it 'justified action'... repeatedly criticizes South's restriction on condolences]. *SBS News*. January 3.

<sup>24</sup> High-level U.S.–North Korea talks were held in New York in July 2011 and in Geneva in October 2011, during which North Korea's willingness to denuclearize was confirmed and discussions on food assistance resumed. Even after these meetings concluded, into early 2012, the U.S. and North Korea continued several working-level contacts in Beijing, coordinating the specifics of preliminary denuclearization measures and food aid.

While this may seem inexplicable given the preceding agreement and promised food aid, the launch occurred on April 13, 2012, just after South Korea's legislative elections on April 11, in which the conservative party secured a dominant majority. North Korea's actions can thus be interpreted as a strong expression of dissatisfaction with South Korea's consolidation of conservative power. This illustrates that North Korean provocations often cannot be fully explained by considering only one side, either the United States or South Korea.

In 2013, President Park Geun-hye was elected in South Korea, continuing the conservative hardline stance toward North Korea. Although the Obama administration's North Korea policy became somewhat strained after the failure of the February 29 agreement, it maintained a two-track approach, keeping dialogue channels open and preserving the same framework as in the early years of the administration.

During this period of divergent policies, North Korea, under Kim Jong-un's succession, consolidated military power and aggressively pursued technological and military advancements alongside its "strong and prosperous nation" pledge. Short-range missile launches increased noticeably, the 2014 West Sea naval combat occurred, and SLBM tests under the Pukguksong-1 program began in 2015. Nuclear tests, including the 3rd–5th tests, were also conducted, and North Korea claimed success in hydrogen bomb testing and standardization of nuclear warheads, ultimately declaring the "completion of national nuclear force." This period is thus regarded as the critical phase in which both United States and South Korea policies failed to curb North Korea's nuclear capabilities. The divergent policies provided North Korea space to negotiate with one side while provoking the other, and the misalignment of U.S.–ROK policy gave North Korea the crucial time to advance its nuclear and missile programs and declare the completion of its national nuclear force.

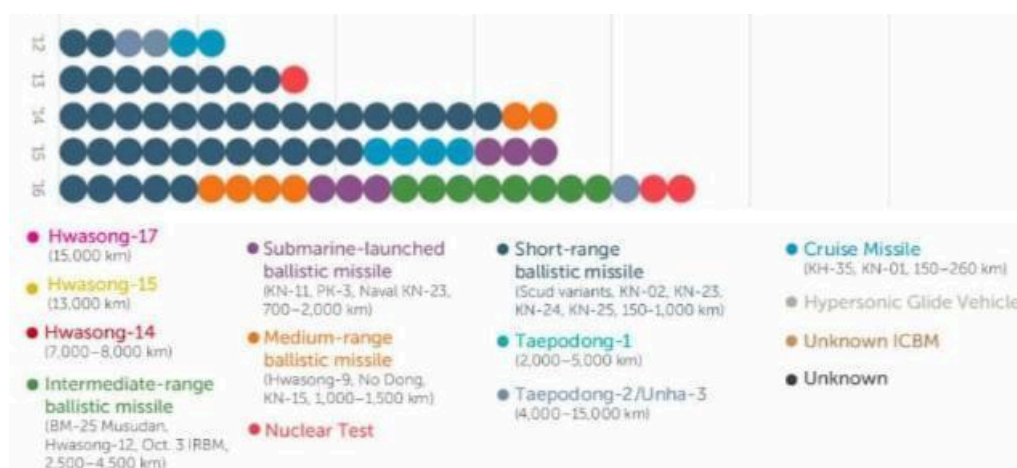


Figure 1 CSIS, <https://missilethreat.csis.org/country/dprk/>

From 2017 onward, both South Korea and the United States entered new administrations, bringing unprecedented changes to their North Korea policies. During this period, under the first Trump administration, the policy shifted significantly in a hard–soft–hard pattern, which had a major impact on North Korean provocations and is therefore examined in detail.

### 2.3. Trump 1<sup>st</sup> – Moon (2017-2018): Hard-Soft

After taking office, President Trump declared the end of former President Obama's "strategic patience" policy and officially articulated a North Korea policy of "Maximum Pressure and Engagement," employing strong rhetoric such as "fire and fury." He introduced a deal-centered approach departing from traditional diplomatic practices, mobilizing unprecedented economic, diplomatic, and military pressure on North Korea. Although the North Korea Sanctions and Policy Enhancement Act (NKSPEA) had already been passed during the final phase of the Obama administration following North Korea's fourth nuclear test, the Trump administration additionally implemented secondary sanctions via Executive Order 13810.<sup>25</sup> + [Its effects \(briefly\)](#)

Meanwhile, with President Moon Jae-in's election, South Korea's North Korea policy shifted dramatically. As a former senior secretary under the Roh Moo-hyun administration, Moon had a firm commitment to the inter-Korean peace policies of the Kim Dae-jung–Roh Moo-hyun lineage, which he concretized in the "Berlin Initiative."<sup>26</sup> Through this approach, the Moon administration sought to resume unconditional inter-Korean dialogue to restore trust and use it as a pathway to explore solutions to the North Korean nuclear issue. This indicates that the two pillars of the U.S.–ROK alliance began from fundamentally different philosophical starting points regarding North Korea.

While the United States and South Korea pursued their respective approaches, North Korea raced to complete its nuclear and missile capabilities. In his 2017 New Year's speech, Chairman Kim Jong-un declared that preparations for ICBM test launches had reached the final stage, and throughout 2017 alone, North Korea fired over 20 missiles. Notably, the ICBMs capable of striking parts of the U.S. mainland flew over Japanese airspace into the Pacific, and the Hwasong-15, with a claimed maximum range of 13,000 km, was launched as well. North Korea also carried out its most powerful nuclear test to date, the sixth nuclear test. It estimated at 50–160 kilotons, several times more powerful than the fifth test.

These provocations led the United States to perceive that North Korea had crossed a "red line." Subsequently, the United States spearheaded the United Nations Security Council (UNSC) Resolution 2397, imposing international sanctions, while simultaneously showing a somewhat more receptive stance toward diplomatic solutions.<sup>27</sup>

#### 2.4. Trump 1<sup>st</sup> – Moon (2019-2022): Hard-Soft

Despite the earlier achievements, the peaceful momentum on the Korean Peninsula stalled again with the Second U.S.-DPRK Summit in Hanoi. The apparent reason for the Hanoi summit's collapse was the differing interpretations of the first Singapore summit statement, but the fundamental cause lies in the resurgence of hardline North Korea policy advocated by neoconservatives, led by John Bolton and Mike Pompeo, who influenced Congress and

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<sup>25</sup> [2017. 9.21.](#)

<sup>26</sup> The "Berlin Initiative" was a key policy framework issued by the Ministry of Unification under the Moon Jae-in administration. Its core principles, the peaceful resolution of the North Korean nuclear issue and the establishment of lasting peace, denuclearization of the Korean Peninsula, and proactive management of inter-Korean affairs, are included.  
<http://oemmnndcbldboiebfnladdacbfmadadm/https://www.unikorea.go.kr/koreapolicy/assets/contents/download.pdf>

<sup>27</sup> The UNSC 2397 (2017) significantly limited imports of refined petroleum to 500,000 barrels per year and mandated the repatriation of all the North Korea overseas workers, which was regarded to have the severe impact on North Korean economy.

effectively overturned the prior peaceful policy approach. While North Korea demanded partial relief from the UNSC sanctions in exchange for the permanent dismantlement of the Yongbyon nuclear facility, which is regarded as the heart of its nuclear program (small deal), the United States demanded a comprehensive declaration and dismantlement of all nuclear materials, nuclear facilities, and WMDs, effectively insisting on a “preemptive denuclearization” (big deal). North Korea’s phased approach and the United States’s insistence on an all-or-nothing deal could not reconcile, and President Trump chose “No deal,” resulting in the breakdown of negotiations. Judging from the first U.S.-DPRK summit’s context and North Korea’s willingness at the time, even slight adjustments could have allowed a negotiated settlement through continued diplomatic effort. However, the U.S. hardliners refused to make any concessions, effectively leading to the current reality in which North Korea has permanently abandoned denuclearization. This is corroborated by Bolton’s memoir, which notes that President Trump later “regretted going too hard.”<sup>28</sup> (John Bolton, *The Room Where It Happened*)

Even as U.S.-DPRK relations became increasingly strained, President Moon continued to pursue peace negotiations and independently sought to advance the denuclearization process. However, the already existing divergence between United States and South Korean policies made coordinated efforts impossible, and North Korea exploited the gap to resume provocations. By the end of 2019, North Korea warned that if the United States did not adopt a new calculation, it would take a new path, and during that period, it conducted consecutive tests of the KN-23 and KN-25 super-large multiple rocket launchers, as well as the new Pukguksong-3 SLBM. When the United States failed to respond as North Korea expected, North Korea escalated further by blowing up the inter-Korean liaison office in June 2020, signaling that negotiations on the nuclear issue had become impossible and that inter-Korean relations had reached an irreparable level of collapse. Subsequently, North Korea closed all channels of communication and carried out unprecedented missile tests.

## 2.5. Biden-Yoon (2022-2023): Soft-Hard

Following the inauguration of President Joe Biden, the administration adopted a new direction in North Korea policy, shifting toward a “soft” approach. The Biden administration took a middle-ground position between the Trump administration’s top-down grand bargain approach and the Obama administration’s strategy of strategic patience, pursuing a “calibrated, practical approach.” It consistently emphasized readiness for unconditional dialogue with North Korea at any time and place through working-level negotiations and expressed commitment to gradual, step-by-step denuclearization measures and peaceful diplomacy.

In contrast, South Korea under President Yoon Suk-yeol shifted its North Korea policy back toward a hardline approach. Departing from the previous government’s engagement-focused policy, President Yoon emphasized “peace through strength” based on the U.S.-ROK combined defense posture, restoring deterrence-centered measures. Accordingly, joint military exercises that had been scaled down during the Moon administration were resumed and intensified.

The Biden administration’s foreign policy prioritized alliances, particularly reinforcing trilateral cooperation with South Korea and Japan. The Yoon administration aligned with this

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<sup>28</sup> “‘I could have made a deal. I could have given away everything.’ A moment later, he said, ‘Maybe I shouldn’t have walked.’ We all chimed in, telling him he had made the right decision.”

emphasis, strengthening ties with Japan and leveraging this framework to enhance U.S.-ROK relations. Some perspectives might interpret this period as a time of well-aligned U.S.-ROK policy coordination. However, focusing specifically on North Korea policy, this study emphasizes the nuanced differences in approach, therefore, the Biden administration is classified as “soft” while South Korea is classified as “hard,” based on attitudes toward dialogue. To be Specific, the Biden administration consistently highlighted the possibility of unconditional dialogue, stressed diplomatic engagement, and even expressed willingness to provide humanitarian aid during the COVID-19 pandemic, reflecting a fundamentally “soft” policy orientation.<sup>29</sup> Conversely, the Yoon administration revived the joint U.S.-ROK exercises under the name *Ulchi Freedom Shield (UFS)*, significantly expanding their scale and deploying strategic assets—including U.S. aircraft carriers, strategic bombers, and nuclear-powered submarines—regularly to the Korean Peninsula. Although these measures were coordinated with U.S. consent, President Yoon unilaterally suspended the enforcement of the 9.19 military agreement and resumed loudspeaker broadcasts toward North Korea, marking a distinctly “hard” posture.

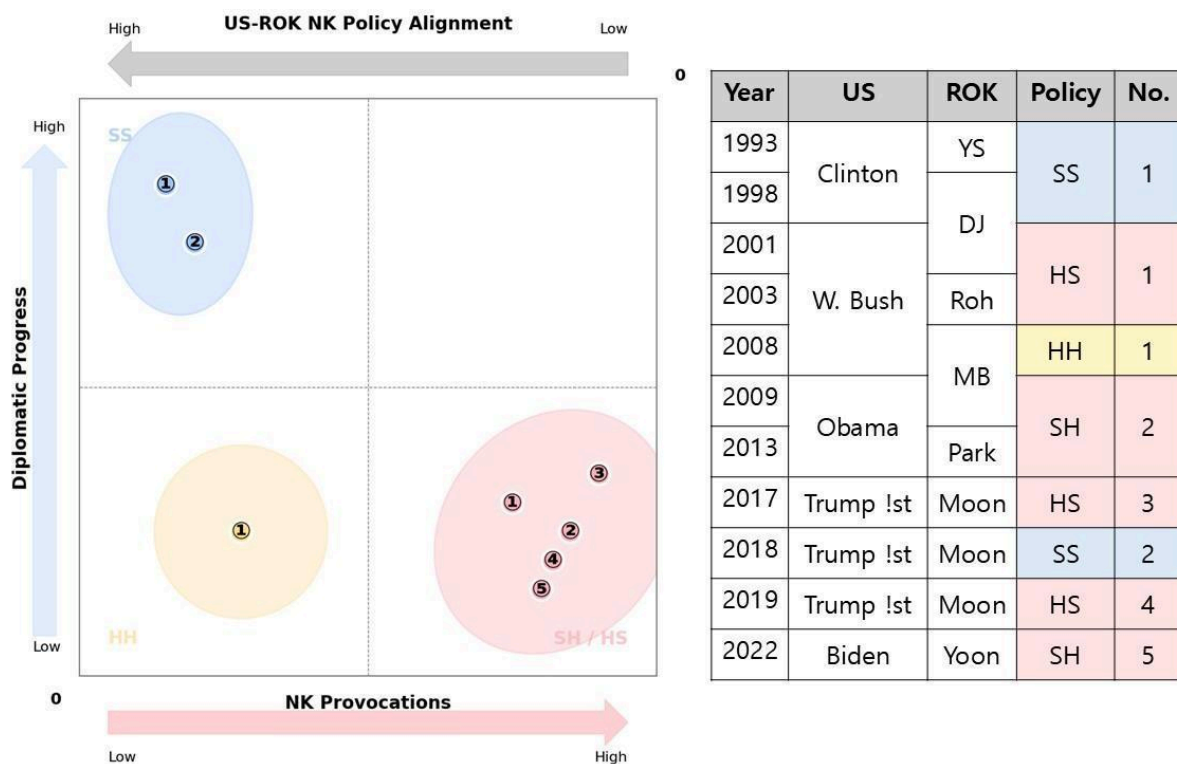
Amid these divergent approaches, North Korea cut off communication channels and escalated provocations. Since 2022, Pyongyang has focused on advancing ICBM technology, developing the Hwasong-17 and Hwasong-18, enhancing capabilities for multiple independently targetable reentry vehicles (MIRVs) and solid-fuel propulsion. Data from Statista indicate that North Korea’s missile launches during this period reached unprecedented levels. Ultimately, this period ended without meaningful diplomatic outcomes, with both Biden’s dialogue-focused approach and Yoon’s strength-based deterrence approach failing to achieve their intended effects, leaving the situation to regress to patterns of past confrontation.



**Figure 3 Statista**

<sup>29</sup> During the Biden administration, senior diplomatic and national security officials, including Secretary of State Antony Blinken, consistently emphasized that “diplomacy is the foremost means for addressing the North Korean issue.”

With these case studies, this research reveals that the level of U.S.-ROK alignment on North Korea policy directly affected North Korea's level of provocation. In the early stage of the Geneva Agreement under 'soft-soft' coordination, North Korea had outwardly complied with the terms of the agreement and refrained from almost all forms of provocations including missile launches until the U.S. delayed implementation of the agreement. Similarly, in 2018, around the Panmunjom Declaration and before the Hanoi negotiations broke down, when visible denuclearization agreements were being reached regarding the Korean Peninsula, North Korea ceased all forms of provocation. Likewise, during the period when both countries jointly adopted a hardline policy, the 'hard-hard' period (2008–2009), North Korea's high-intensity provocations were absent, which can be analyzed as reflecting the judgment that there was no strategic gain in provoking in the face of a united hardline front. On the other hand, exceptions in which North Korea rapidly escalated provocations, including nuclear tests and long-range missile launches, occurred without exception when the policies of the two countries diverged into 'soft-hard/hard-soft' or when existing agreements were not implemented, resulting in policy dissonance.



**Figure 4 Correlation between ROK–US North Korea Policy Combinations and North Korean Provocations and Diplomatic Progress (Source: Author).**

The figure above visually summarizes the combinations of U.S.-ROK North Korea policies analyzed in this study and the corresponding levels of North Korean provocation and diplomatic progress. The horizontal axis at the bottom represents North Korea's level of provocation (Low ↔ High), the vertical axis represents the level of diplomatic progress (Low ↔ High), and the top horizontal axis, starting from the right, indicates the level of U.S.-ROK policy coordination (Low ↔ High). 'S' stands for 'Soft,' and 'H' stands for 'Hard,' and each policy combination (SS, HH, SH/HS) is grouped by color to clearly show the correlation

between the policies and outcomes.

As shown in the figure, when U.S.-ROK policy alignment was high, both ‘Soft-Soft’ (blue) and ‘Hard-Hard’ (yellow) periods saw North Korea’s provocations remain relatively low. While ‘Soft-Soft’ coordination led to high diplomatic achievements, ‘Hard-Hard’ coordination resulted in a deadlock without diplomatic progress. In contrast, periods in which the two countries’ policies were inconsistent, such as ‘Soft-Hard’ or ‘Hard-Soft’ (red), without exception resulted in high-level provocations and diplomatic failure.

Given that this study spans more than thirty years, it is difficult to precisely quantify the level of provocations in each period. Accordingly, provocations are conceptualized simply as ‘high’ or ‘low,’ with minor variations within the red-circled periods not considered significant for this analysis. This figure is intended to provide an intuitive illustration of the correlation between ROK–U.S. policy coordination and North Korea’s behavior.

### **The Post-Hanoi Shift: Decoupling from the U.S.-ROK Framework**

■ 자원 조달처의 변경 (Resource Diversification): 과거에는 미국으로부터 제재 완화와 경제 지원을 얻기 위해 한국을 흔드는 방식을 썼다면, 이제는 러시아라는 확실한 대체 시장을 찾았습니다. 포탄과 미사일을 주고 식량, 에너지, 고도 기술을 직접 챙기는 '실질적 거래'가 성사된 것이죠.

■ 도발의 양상 변화 (Shift in Provocation Style): "도발이 줄었다"는 느낌을 받으시는 이유는 과거처럼 미국을 협상 테이블로 끌어내기 위한 \*\*관심 끌기용 쇼맨십 도발\*\*이 줄었기 때문입니다. 대신 지금은 \*\*실전 배치용 성능 테스트\*\*에 집중합니다. 즉, 남들에게 보여주기 위한 화려한 불꽃놀이보다 내실 있는 무기 체계 완성을 조용히 밀어붙이고 있는 국면입니다.

■ 미국이라는 자원의 가치 하락: 북한 입장에서 "미국과 협상해봐야 시간만 뺏기고 얻는 게 없다"는 하노이의 교훈이 뼈아팠던 것입니다. 이제 미국을 흔드는 데 에너지를 쓰기보다, 미국을 '상수(Constant)'로 두고 무시하며 자기 갈 길을 가는 전략입니다.

## **V. Conclusion: Implications for U.S.-ROK Strategic Cohesion**

Historically, North Korea has often been depicted in the United States as an unpredictable and irrational actor, while South Korea has appeared to be passively reactive to North Korea's sudden actions and provocations. However, as demonstrated in this study, North Korea's provocations are not the result of irrational impulses but rather strategic actions carefully calculated to exploit policy gaps between the United States and South Korea.<sup>30</sup> Such strategic behavior tends to emerge selectively when fissures in the bilateral policy alignment occur, and North Korea has leveraged these gaps as an opportune moment for coercive diplomacy.

This study does not deny the existence of other external factors not directly addressed, such as United Nations sanctions, internal regime stability, or economic conditions within North Korea. Moreover, national foreign policy is not formulated and executed instantaneously, and time lags may exist due to domestic decision-making processes. Nonetheless, this research focuses on identifying patterns in North Korea's behavior and systematically analyzing their correlation with U.S.-ROK policy alignment. Other internal and external factors are therefore left as avenues for future in-depth research.

The study clearly demonstrates that the most critical variable in North Korea's provocations is the level of U.S.-ROK policy coordination. From this, it can be inferred that establishing a consistent and coordinated policy framework is a key prerequisite for altering North Korea's strategic calculus and promoting stability on the Korean Peninsula. However, domestic politics in both countries, particularly periodic leadership changes due to elections, have structurally impeded the pursuit of coherent and stable North Korea policies. The orientation of inter-Korean policy shifts significantly depending on the ruling party and the political leader's disposition, and differences in threat perception and solution-seeking approaches based on national interests often result in policy misalignment between the United States and South Korea.

Unlike the previous era of U.S. unipolar hegemony, the contemporary international order is moving toward a multipolar system amid U.S.–China strategic competition, meaning that North Korea can no longer be considered solely a Korean Peninsula issue. Considering North Korea's geopolitical position and its relations with China and Russia, security challenges on the Korean Peninsula are closely linked to regional stability throughout the broader Indo-Pacific. This changing international landscape provides a strategic incentive for the United States and South Korea, as allies, to jointly address North Korea and ensure regional stability.

Accordingly, both countries should recognize that North Korea is not merely an irrational actor and seek practical measures to bring it to the negotiating table based on closely coordinated and mutually agreed policies. North Korea, for its part, has sufficiently learned from past policy shifts and failures to implement agreements. Recent reports by the Korean Central News Agency indicate that as of 2025, the situation has clearly changed from that of

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<sup>30</sup> In this study, the conceptual definition of North Korea's provocations refers specifically to actions intended to convey a desired message through retaliation or coercive diplomacy in response to preceding events. Routine activities such as missile performance tests during development stages were not weighted heavily in this interpretation. Given the extremely limited access to internal information within North Korea, assessments must rely largely on observable external indicators. Consequently, some ambiguity in this distinction is inevitable. Nevertheless, by analyzing events chronologically and tracing causal relationships, it is possible to infer, to a certain extent, that North Korea's actions were driven by deliberate intent.

2018–2019.<sup>31</sup> While North Korea maintains that nuclear confrontation is not mutually beneficial and alternative approaches must be sought, Kim Jong-un's remark that his personal relationship with former U.S. President Trump is not negative suggests that the country has not entirely closed off avenues for dialogue. (KCNA, 2025) Moving forward, the United States and South Korea should draw lessons from past policy successes and failures, and strategically leverage North Korea's calculated posture to generate momentum for renewed diplomatic engagement through closely coordinated policy measures.

- + Foreign policy based on national interests (believed at the time) from the short-sighted perspective, ultimately produced adverse consequences in the long run
  - + That were justified on the grounds for serving the immediate national interest
- + i.e. NK turned out to be strengthening military ties with Russia after the failure of the Hanoi Summit (it gave no choice but making another breakthrough to address their economic needs)

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